What Do IT Support Specialists Do? And How To Become One

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KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- An IT support specialist helps manage the technical and administrative tasks involved in the planning, installation and maintenance of a company's computers, workstations and servers.
- An IT support specialist, also known as an IT support technician or technical support specialist, has a strong background in technology, computer hardware and software.
- IT support specialists often help those outside of the tech industry understand and use complex tech systems, so it's beneficial if you can explain these concepts clearly and solve technical problems for other departments.

An IT support specialist, also known as an IT support technician or technical support specialist, has a strong background in technology, computer hardware and software. These individuals help organizations optimize their technology usage, address and resolve technical issues and manage technological equipment to better meet their business needs. If you're a problem solver with advanced information technology skills, you may want to consider a career this career path.

In this article, we explain what IT support specialists are and what they do, share details about their work environments and salaries and explain how to start and grow a career in this field.

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Technical support Hiring Insights

Average pay

$23.45 / hour

Low $7.25 **High** $54.60

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393

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What is an IT support specialist?

An IT support specialist helps manage the technical and administrative tasks involved in the planning, installation and maintenance of a company's computers, workstations and servers. Those in this role often work as a help desk technician, diagnosing any issues that users might have with their computer technology. They might also work as part of an IT department in-house, such as for a healthcare or financial institution.

They provide users with desktop support for software programs (such as operating systems) or installing firewalls. They might also advise on data storage solutions and accessories like printers and monitors to assess their compatibility. In person, they might install, upgrade and troubleshoot hardware and software on behalf of their employer and track performance and progress via reports.

If you plan to enter this field, it helps to have strong communication skills and knowledge of common computer systems. IT support specialists often help those outside of the tech industry understand and use complex tech systems, so it's beneficial if you can explain these concepts clearly and solve technical problems for other departments.

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What does an IT support specialist do?

The IT support specialist is a high-demand position primarily because their function is crucial to the successful daily operations of most businesses. An IT support specialist can expect to perform the following tasks:

- Assist users in troubleshooting common computer issues or concerns
- Reply to requests for IT services, repairs, support, inquiries or complaints
- Refer user messages or calls to the appropriate IT personnel
- Use a computer tracking system to manage new tickets
- Make recommendations to improve computer systems
- Provide documentation for customer support inquiries and resolutions
- Upgrade and manage systems to ensure they are operating effectively and efficiently
- Implement new business and productivity software

- Train staff on new software, systems and best practices
- Maintain and back up security databases
- Update knowledge bases for employees
- Interact with hardware and software vendors
- Repair, select and upgrade the organization's hardware
- Document all technical processes, upgrades and decisions
- Hire and train entry-level IT support specialists

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Salary and job outlook for IT support specialists

The national average salary for a support specialist is $56,643 per year. Remember that individual salaries can vary by industry, geographic location, education level and experience. IT support specialists can vary in seniority and responsibilities, and senior-level specialists could earn more than entry-level specialists.

The job outlook for this career is positive, as the United States Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) reports that all computer occupations could grow 6% by 203 3. The BLS expects jobs for computer user support specialists to grow by 5% and jobs for computer network support specialists to grow by 7%.

According to the BLS, this demand could be because of the ongoing need for support, maintenance and upgrades on software and hardware, but automation tools and outsourcing could influence the industry, too. For the most up-to-date salary information from Indeed, click on the link(s) provided.

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Skills for an IT support specialist

An It support specialist is technologically savvy and comfortable troubleshooting computer issues. A successful IT support specialist also has the following skills:

- **Analytical:** Many of the problems you work to solve are highly technical in nature, and analytical thinking can help you approach situations and determine a creative and thoughtful solution. A skilled IT support specialist understands that there may be many moving parts that could cause a system error.
- **Technical skills:** A solid understanding of computer software and hardware, computer networking and cybersecurity is essential. Users rely on you for credible information on these topics, so it's important that you can serve as an authority.
- **Communication:** Much of this role involves communicating with customers, in-house users and hardware and software vendors. Strong communication skills can help you give effective written instructions and advice via email or chat and clear verbal directions in person or over the phone.
- **Organization**: IT professionals often have to manage many tasks at once, oversee documentation and manage their time to complete all necessary tasks. Organizational skills can help you keep all of your ticket requests in order.
- **Patience:** Users you support may have little experience and knowledge about computer systems. Staying patient can help you effectively explain how the user can fix their problem while keeping your composure.
- **Problem-solving:** Troubleshooting is a major part of your job, as you may repair malfunctioning equipment or systems and devise solutions to recurring issues. Having problem-solving skills can help you approach these issues logically and reach solutions quickly.

Related: IT Specialist Skills: Definition and Examples

How to become an IT support specialist

Below are some steps you could follow to begin your career in IT support:

1. Earn a college degree

Employers typically look for candidates with strong computer skills. While they may consider candidates with only a high school degree, earning an associate degree or a bachelor's degree in computer science or a related area of study can help you distinguish yourself from other candidates. Some level of formal training in computer systems is typically a requirement for entry-level IT jobs.

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2. Develop your soft skills

Along with your technical skills, develop the soft skills necessary for this role. Practice active listening to show that you can fully understand a user's needs and find the right solution for them.

IT support specialists interface with a variety of people, like other IT staff members, employees at the company they support and vendor representatives, so it's helpful to develop communication and interpersonal skills, too.

3. Apply for an entry-level job or internship

While there are plenty of entry-level IT jobs, you can also enter this career through an internship. During your internship, ask thoughtful questions and try to network as much as you can. Often, an internship can turn into a full-time position. When applying for internships or entry-level roles, remember to highlight your hard skills on your IT resume with specific software names and resume keywords.

Read more: How To Get an Entry-Level IT Job (With Jobs List)

How to advance as an IT support specialist

After working an entry-level IT support job, you may see opportunities to grow your career. Follow these steps to advance your career as an IT support specialist:

1. Earn certifications

Earning certifications proves to employers that you have a specialized set of skills. Some companies hire IT support specialists to provide service for one platform or area of expertise. Consider earning one of the following certifications:

- **Microsoft Azure Fundamentals:** This base-level certification from Microsoft demonstrates your skills in Azure, Microsoft's cloud storage solution. It also shows employers your overall understanding of cloud computing models and technologies.
- **CompTIA A+ Certification:** This certification from CompTIA shows employers you have a solid foundation of hardware, technical support and troubleshooting. You will also learn about topics like operational procedures, mobile devices and security.
- **Cisco Certified Network Association (CCNA):** The CCNA credential is an entry-level certification focusing on computer networking. It covers topics like network access, security, automation and Internet Protocol (IP) issues.
- **Certified Information Security Manager (CISM):** This credential from Information Systems Audit and Control Association (ISACA) can help you develop a fundamental understanding of IT security measures and qualify you for more advanced security responsibilities. It focuses on areas like incident management, security governance and risk management.
- **Certified in Cybersecurity:** The International Information System Security Certification Consortium issues this credential to qualified candidates who showcase their ability to develop an effective cybersecurity program. This helps you demonstrate to employers that you know how to implement and manage authentication and data protection protocols.

Read more: 15 IT Certifications To Enhance Your Credentials

2. Gain experience

After a few years of working in a role where you support in-house users or customers, you can eventually get promoted to a higher-level position within your company. Prove that you have the skills to improve the design and effectiveness of the company's computer systems.

If you work for a software or hardware company, you may even have more room for growth. Eventually, you could advance to roles such as a software developer or computer systems administrator.

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3. Build your professional network

Connecting with other people in the industry can help you advance your career. Join different IT professional groups where you can connect with fellow IT support specialists. Whenever you attend networking events, always bring multiple copies of your business card to hand out. Ensure to follow up with people you meet and maintain a professional connection.

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Work environment for IT support specialists

Most IT support specialists work in an office environment. They can work for companies in a variety of industries, such as finance, sales, technology and telecommunications. Some IT support specialists work at a help desk where users can approach them in person, while others may work at their own desks. Some employers may require specialists to visit clients in person at their offices, too.

Please note that none of the companies mentioned in this article are affiliated with Indeed.

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